GROWTH BLUEPRINT ADVISORY

Technology & Digital

The Saudi market-entry brief

THE SECTOR IN PLAIN WORDS

Before we start

Saudi organisations are investing seriously in digital: cloud, data, cybersecurity, automation and AI. For a technology company that is good news, but the buying journey is not the one you may know. Big deals are shaped by procurement rules, local presence, data requirements and long relationships.

This brief is for software, platform and digital services companies deciding how to sell to Saudi enterprises and government. It explains how buyers decide, which data and security questions come up early, and what a realistic first year looks like.

In this brief

1. The sector in plain words
2. What is driving demand
3. How the market is organised
4. Ways in
5. Rules to check early
6. Partners: who you will meet
7. Where people go wrong
8. Your first 90 days
9. Questions to ask before you commit

Please note. This brief is general guidance written by advisers. It is not legal, tax or investment advice. Rules and programmes change, so confirm current requirements with the relevant authority and licensed advisers before you act. We do not include market-size statistics because they date quickly; ask us for current figures.

Licensed for single-user internal use. Please do not share, resell or publish. © 2026 Growth Blueprint Advisory.

02

What is driving demand

National digital transformation

Public programmes and large enterprises are modernising systems and services at pace.

A young, connected population

High digital adoption drives demand for consumer-facing digital services.

Investment in cloud, data and AI

Spending on infrastructure and platforms creates demand for software and services around them.

Preference for local presence

Buyers, especially in government, increasingly expect suppliers to have a local footprint and support.

03

How the market is organised

The market at a glance.

Who buys	Government bodies, large enterprises, banks, telecoms, energy and fast-growing private companies.
How they buy	Through formal tenders, framework agreements, partners and integrators, often with evaluation of local presence.
What they ask early	Where data is hosted, how it is secured, who supports it locally and in Arabic.
What decides success	A credible local presence or partner, strong references, and patience with long sales cycles.
Typical first move	Partner with a local integrator and win one reference customer before building a larger team.

04

Ways in

Reseller or integrator partnership

A local partner sells and implements. Fast to start; quality and loyalty depend on the partner.

Direct sales with a small local team

More control and margin; needs entity, hires and patience.

Regional headquarters or hub

Required or beneficial for some government work. Check current expectations and incentives.

Marketplace or platform listing

Lower effort for some products, usually for smaller deals.

05

Rules to check early

Confirm these early, with the relevant authority and a licensed adviser.

- [ ] Personal data protection requirements and how they apply to your product.
- [ ] National cybersecurity controls and cloud requirements that buyers will ask you about.
- [ ] Government procurement processes and supplier registration, which have formal steps.
- [ ] Local presence or regional headquarters expectations for government contracts, which have been evolving. Confirm the current position.
- [ ] Entity, licensing and tax requirements for selling services and software locally.

06

Partners: who you will meet

Integrators and resellers

Check references, certifications and how many products they already carry.

Cloud and infrastructure providers

Where your data is hosted often shapes who can buy from you.

Consultancies

Influence what government and large enterprises choose, and can open doors.

Recruiters and training providers

Technical talent is competitive. Plan hiring early.

07

Where people go wrong

Treating it like a quick sale

Deals can take many months and several approval layers.

Ignoring data and hosting questions

They come up early and can end a sale if you have no answer.

English-only materials

Arabic documentation and support matter to many buyers.

Choosing a partner on introductions alone

A well-connected partner who cannot deliver is a liability.

No local reference

Buyers want to see who else in the Kingdom uses you.

08

Your first 90 days

Days 1 to 30: understand

- Map target buyers and how each procures.
- Prepare clear answers on data hosting, security and support.
- Translate key materials into Arabic.

Days 31 to 60: find partners

- Shortlist integrators or resellers and compare on the same criteria.
- Run one or two pilot conversations with potential customers.
- Take advice on entity and tax.

Days 61 to 90: pilot

- Agree a pilot with one customer and one partner.
- Set measures for success and support responsibilities.
- Plan hiring for the first local roles.

09

Questions to ask before you commit

Take these into your next meeting. If you cannot answer one, that is your next piece of homework.

- [ ] Who will sign, who will influence, and how do they procure?
- [ ] Where will our customers' data live, and can we meet their requirements?
- [ ] Do we need a local entity or regional presence to win this work?
- [ ] Who will support customers locally, and in Arabic?
- [ ] Which partner gives us the best chance of a first reference?
- [ ] How long is the realistic sales cycle, and can we fund it?
- [ ] What does a successful pilot look like?
- [ ] What do we stop doing if the first year does not go to plan?

ملخص بالعربية

التقنية والرقمية: موجز دخول السوق السعودي

يوضح هذا الموجز كيف تشتري المؤسسات والجهات الحكومية في السعودية الحلول التقنية، ولماذا تتشكل الصفقات الكبيرة عبر إجراءات المشتريات والحضور المحلي ومتطلبات البيانات والعلاقات طويلة الأمد. ستجد أسئلة الاستضافة والأمن التي تظهر مبكرًا، وأنواع الشركاء، وأخطاء شائعة، وخطة لأول ٩٠ يومًا. وخلاصتنا: ابدأ بشريك محلي وعميل مرجعي واحد، وجهّز مواد بالعربية، وخطط لدورة مبيعات طويلة.

هذا الموجز إرشاد عام كتبه مستشارون، وليس مشورة قانونية أو ضريبية أو استثمارية. تتغير الأنظمة والبرامج، فتأكد دائمًا من المتطلبات الحالية مع الجهة المختصة ومستشارين مرخّصين.